

Read This First: A Regime Theory of Joy

This article introduces the theory behind M-ZRT and should be read before the exercise catalog

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A Regime Theory of Joy is a theory I developed independently that seeks to explain the mechanisms underlying joy. I argue that joy has so far largely escaped scientific investigation because of its elusive nature. In particular, it does not tolerate evaluation at entry.

Importantly, the second contribution of this work is the proposal of a mechanistically grounded task, specifically designed to induce joy.

In A Regime Theory of Joy, joy refers to a specific positive affective state characterized by a pleasant radiating sensation in the chest together with heightened olfactory sensitivity. This specific, intensive and abrupt phenomenology can in part rule out placebo or simple novelty effects.

Increased olfactory sensitivity may reflect greater engagement of the hippocampal system. If so, the hippocampus's role in contextual memory and associative processing could increase the richness and diversity of subjective experience, producing a wider range of positive "textures." In this state, colors may feel unusually vivid, almost like tasting candy, odors can evoke the feeling of entering a different world, and small shimmering objects may spontaneously elicit rich mental imagery.

This may explain why certain moments, especially during childhood, when access to this state is hypothesized to be easier, are remembered as unique.

A common idea is that the environment created the feeling. Instead, the environment may have acted as an amplifier of an already accessible brain configuration.

In principle, that would imply that spending an indefinite time in such a positive state may be theoretically possible.

Joy as a Problem of Causal Rigidity

According to the regime theory of joy, the primary bottleneck preventing joy is not a lack of reward or dopamine, but the increasing rigidity of learned causal chains. As we learn, the brain accumulates countless cause-and-effect relationships that organize perception and behavior. This accumulated rigidity is captured by the variable Z . Z progressively recruits a control regime specialized for prediction, optimization, and reliable action, but one that is incompatible with the regime of ease associated with joy.

Imagine a desk with a computer and a pencil. Each object recruits an enormous network of learned causal relationships, action tendencies, and predictions. A pencil is considered less valuable than a computer, so it is treated as more disposable. It is picked up in a particular way, used for writing while monitoring spelling, returned to its usual place, and often checked afterward to make sure it has not been misplaced.

These rules are also tied to object categorization: a pencil is "just a pencil," a computer is valuable because of its many functions, and each object automatically recruits its expected meaning and use.

As learning accumulates, behavior becomes increasingly organized around local optimization. Each selected action automatically recruits the next preferred policy. M-ZRT (Minimal Z-reduction task) introduces small discontinuities into these chains before they fully stabilize.

Why M-ZRT Targets Optimization

Perception, thoughts, and actions naturally become organized around optimization. M-ZRT introduces brief perturbations that suspend this optimization before it recruits the next policy. Some tasks briefly perturb object categories, others interrupt familiar action sequences, and others leave sequences incomplete. Together, these small perturbations are proposed to reduce the rigidity of the underlying action structure, making the ease regime more likely to emerge.

Each ZRT exercise is effective only if the brain treats it as a minor, inconsequential perturbation. This is the central challenge of the method. It is also difficult because it runs counter to the principles of flow, a framework that is deeply ingrained. This makes the task psychologically counterintuitive.

If it is approached too seriously, the brain naturally re-engages comparison, evaluation, prediction, and monitoring. According to the theory, this reactivates the control regime that competes with the ease regime. At that point, the task no longer increases the probability of entering a joy-compatible state: It may even reduce it.

To illustrate this principle, consider the first exercise: **Alter Your Path.**

Normally, the player runs directly toward a destination. During the exercise *Alter Your Path*, the player introduces a small, purposeless deviation. They may change direction for a second or casually walk around an unimportant object before resuming their original route.

The primary activity is moving through the game world. Alter Your Path is the disturbance. Beginners often find Alter Your Path surprisingly difficult because it interrupts an ongoing action sequence. What is interesting is that many people find it easier to perform a complicated task than to introduce a small arbitrary disruption into an action that is already underway. Some people will have less difficulty solving a puzzle or meditating than walking for two seconds in a slightly different direction.

With experience, however, even more advanced exercises become easier.

The system needs to learn that this is a valid behavioral pattern. Repeating the same exercise too rigidly continues the optimization process rather than relaxing it. Instead, the system must learn that behavior does not always need to be optimized.

Before You Begin the Task

This task involves a shift in brain regime, from one in which comparison, anticipation, and evaluation dominate, to one in which optimization is temporarily suspended. As a result, simply engaging in a serious question is already enough to move out of the target regime.

Constructing a hierarchy also recruits the opposite regime, because hierarchy necessarily depends on evaluation and comparison. Asking "Which exercise should I do, and when?" already moves the brain away from the intended regime.

The protocol begins by treating every option as equally acceptable. Doing an exercise or not doing it, using a game or not using a game, starting now, later, or not doing it at all. Before anything else, no option needs to rank above another. Only then should the protocol begin.

The exercise should not become something that must be performed. It remains only an available perturbation. If the opportunity appears, it may be used. If it is not used, the protocol is still being followed. Skipping the exercise is not a failure, but one of the acceptable outcomes.

Attempting to optimize recruits the very processes the task is designed to suspend. By contrast, refraining from optimization naturally engages the same mechanisms targeted by several M-ZRT exercises, even before the formal task begins.

Before beginning the task, it may help to say once: "*There is nothing to optimize here.*" Saying it repeatedly to make the task more effective is itself an attempt at optimization, and therefore already shifts processing toward the opposite regime.

Before beginning the task, all available options should be regarded as equally acceptable.

Regarding mental activity, it is advisable to avoid what strongly recruits optimization, especially imagined conversations.

Beyond that, it is generally preferable not to interfere with ongoing thoughts. Exercises that directly target thought processes are among the most difficult for beginners. In practice, there is no need to achieve a particular mental state before starting. If thoughts arise, they arise.

You can even apply M-ZRT to the task itself. If the task is performed in a game, occasionally launch the game and immediately close it instead of beginning the session. At other times, let the cursor pass over the game's icon without selecting it. On some occasions, after moving the cursor onto the icon, wait five seconds before clicking. Briefly treat the task itself as having no particular function before beginning it. All those are examples, and none are better than the others.

Ideal Requirements

Outdoors, most exercises become significantly harder because the everyday environment continuously recruits action planning.

A third-person game; an inventory with valuable items; a peaceful town or safe area without combat or quest. Most RPGs and action RPGs (Diablo-like games) therefore provide it.

Beginner Protocol

Here are a few exercises to start with. These are true beginner exercises, although many people will still find them surprisingly difficult at first.

Do not spam the exercises. It is important to leave periods of normal gameplay between them.

A common mistake is to immediately evaluate whether the perturbation worked. Doing so recruits a new task, one centered on outcome evaluation. The original automatic recruitment is replaced by another, rather than being left unresolved, increasing Z.

As stated earlier, every option is acceptable. Doing the exercise, not doing it, using a game, not using a game, starting now, starting later. Nothing needs to rank above anything else before you begin.

Alter Your Path (*Action optimization*)

In a video game without combat, take control of your character and simply walk or run. After about two seconds of continuous movement, you may notice that the brain

automatically begins assigning a purpose to it: "I'm heading toward the door," "I'm looking for a hallway," or "I'm going over there."

If a plan begins to feel established, break-it by altering your trajectory. The deviation should remain brief. It is about breaking the brain's plan.

Visually, it produces a somewhat unusual sequence, which you can see here: <https://youtu.be/kFQZ4VsY1sw?si=k9tMHf5Vc6FZByNz&t=69>. It appears strange because the player is repeatedly interrupting the ongoing action (way too much for a beginner, actually).

One-Word Drift (Semantic optimization)

Look at an object. Let one unrelated word pass through.
Chair → moon Cursor → bird. The object and the word merely touch briefly in awareness. Because the word appears and disappears quickly, the exercise can be performed with almost no cognitive effort.

Another Possible Time (Prediction optimization)

After seeing the current time, briefly imagine a different time appearing on the display instead 11:24 → 7:13

Cursor Passing (Action selection optimization)

Let the cursor pass over an object, NPC, skill, menu option, or button without selecting it. The cursor passes over the target without selecting it.

Functional to Incidental (Functional optimization)

Briefly look at one visual detail that is currently irrelevant to the action you are performing.

Incomplete Caption (Completion optimization)

Looking at something, an internal description starts but remains unfinished. Example: "This is a..."

How does it work?

Looking at an object rapidly recruits several optimization processes:

- *selecting its function,*
- *stabilizing its category,*
- *retrieving its associations,*
- *predicting what comes next,*
- *preparing an action,*
- *assigning its relative importance.*

One-Word Drift briefly suspends this optimization before one continuation becomes dominant.

These processes increase Z. **One-Word Drift** briefly destabilizes this automatic recruitment, temporarily lowering Z, increasing the odds of a regime shift. However, if the exercise is performed with analysis, anticipation, or verification of its effects, the brain automatically recruits another set of action policies, increasing Z instead.

Conclusion

Once these exercises are understood and used naturally, they may already have opened a brief episode of joy, or perhaps even the ease regime. You can find many other exercises that I have personally tested and validated:

florianmorin.com/assets/pdf/Morin2026-Joy-Requires-Reduced-Action-Coupling.pdf

They can be applied in a wide variety of contexts, and some target action mechanisms more directly and more aggressively. This makes it possible to modulate the intensity of the intervention more rapidly, and, depending on the situation, the intensity of joy itself, if you got the ease regime opened.

References:

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. *SSRN*, <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>

Morin, Florian, Evaluative Monitoring and Access to Intense Positive Affect: The Minimal Z-Reduction Task Framework (June 06, 2026). Available at SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=6888300> or <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6888300>